SELARIN

ARAMERE & CALDRIS

A Traveler's Gazetteer



PLACES • PEOPLE • FAITHS

From the fields of Hearthglen to the courts, markets, and harbors of two kingdoms.

742 AR / The Age of Inheritance

Galoris Gaming

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Welcome to the Western Roads

A traveler’s companion

A traveler's companion

In Aramere, grain wagons and river barges bind farming villages to royal terraces and crowded ports. West of the Crownspine, Caldris offers chartered markets, woodland roads, and a city where every spoken word may be true without telling the whole story. This guide introduces the people, places, and customs a traveler can expect to encounter in 742 AR.

Finding your welcome

Look for the Welcoming Door at a refuge, the Sheltered Drop at a house of healing, or the Witness Tablet beside a reader's desk. A letter of introduction may travel farther than coin, especially when a local keeper knows someone at your destination. Most people honor several gods as their needs change.

Reading the entries

Each entry describes the settlement, its public authorities, notable establishments, primary faiths, and connections to neighboring communities. Population figures are approximate and exclude seasonal visitors; Hearthglen's count includes its dependent farms. The named temples are the most visible places of worship, not a census of every household shrine.

Descriptions concern ordinary public life. A ruler's title tells you who holds an office; it does not tell you every private loyalty. Travelers will hear disagreements about roads, history, and worship even among people who otherwise trust one another.

Before you set out

Ask locally about water levels, road repairs, seasonal markets, and places to sleep. Carriers can introduce guides and sell seats when they have room. Refuges help people in need, but their supplies and beds are finite. A village healer can often treat an ordinary injury and advise where more specialized care may be found.

Aramere and Caldris are at peace. Their institutions compete and negotiate across borders, while families, temples, and commercial partnerships connect them. A familiar name on a letter can turn a distant town into a place where someone is expecting you.

Ask also about creature sightings along the next day's road. A wardens' bell, a reinforced stable gate, or a notice at a bridge may be a response to a real hazard rather than local superstition. Even the busiest routes sometimes skirt older, wilder places.

Aramere

The River Kingdom



Land and character

Aramere occupies the central and south-central basin east of the lower Crownspine. Broad fields, river terraces, orchards, and pasture support one of Selarin's largest populations. Its wealth is conspicuous at harvest: queues of loaded wagons, barges riding low in the water, and public granaries whose doors bear several different seals.

The river plain has warm summers and cool winters. Spring flooding is an expected burden, made dangerous by neglected banks or unusual Breathweather. Western uplands are less fertile but give access to Khardun and Caldris. Villages there often feel more connected to a market road than to the royal capital.

Regional creatures & dangers

On the settled river roads, danger is less frequent than at the edges of the basin. Owlbears and dire wolves are reported in wooded uplands when prey runs scarce, while great boars and giant spiders trouble isolated coppices and neglected sheds. Marsh channels sometimes shelter large serpents or other aggressive water creatures; boatmen mark suspect banks and avoid landing there after dark. Old workings near waystones can present stranger hazards, especially during unsettled Breathweather.

Most villages treat such threats as practical problems. Watch bells, reinforced pens, experienced guides, and shared sightings usually matter more than extravagant claims of a curse. Travelers should ask a reeve, ferryman, or carrier for recent reports instead of assuming every forest is unsafe.

Aramere

The River Kingdom / continued

Government and the crown

King Edric Vaun rules from Aurenhall. The River Compact of 287 AR bound older principalities to common responsibilities for granaries, navigation, and flood works. Provincial houses retain substantial local authority, while major towns expect a voice in the River Council. The king's legitimacy rests partly on ensuring that these obligations are met.

Edric is deliberate in public and impatient in working meetings. He wants western roads improved so Aramere can trade without depending entirely on Serathian customs houses. He seeks surveyors, reliable reports, and officials who can finish a bridge without turning it into a quarrel over precedence.

The River Council

Seat: the Compact House in Aurenhall. First Speaker: Lady Ysabet Rennel, a provincial landholder known for making ministers answer the same question until they give a usable answer. The council negotiates reserve targets, navigation rules, and shared expenditure. Its votes do not automatically settle every local dispute: provincial officers must still carry decisions into effect.

Ysabet supports the western-road policy but demands that poorer districts receive maintenance money as well as new construction. Petitioners normally approach through a town delegate or provincial clerk. Testimony from a village can matter if someone has properly recorded it.

The Granary Trust

Warden-General: Tomas Reed, based at the Seven Granaries in Aurenhall. This public institution supervises crown reserves and inspects participating town stores. Local keepers retain their keys; inventories and releases require witnesses from more than one office. The Trust purchases grain, pays carriers, and calls on local authorities for protection.

Tomas distrusts impressive totals that cannot be matched to actual sacks. His inspectors employ escorts, assess storm damage, and investigate claims of spoiled reserves. They can request records but cannot confiscate a family's harvest merely by showing a badge.

The Bankwardens

Chief Warden: Della Marr, a dwarf engineer whose office travels between flood districts. The Bankwardens maintain gauges, embankments, channels, and emergency plans with local labor crews. Their authority concerns public waterworks, not every stream or millpond in the kingdom. Farmers respect their flood warnings and argue fiercely over who supplies the workers.

Faith and ordinary life

Ilyra's seasonal keepers advise on planting and soil; Mereth's healers tend crowded markets and isolated farms. Elsiran houses turn hospitality into dependable shelter. A household may honor all three. Festivals often include a useful obligation: filling a reserve bin, clearing a ditch, or delivering food to someone who cannot attend.

The Grain War with Serath, 603-607 AR, remains a warning about the cost of disrupted trade. Today's Auren Navigation Accord supports peace, but inspections, damaged cargo, and disputed dues still produce work for advocates and escorts. Aramere's people usually fear a failed harvest before they fear an invading army.

Primary faiths

Ilyra, Mereth, and Elsira are the most widely visible faiths. Seasonal Keepers exchange seed and weather records between Aurenhall, Fairmead, and rural houses. Mereth's urban hospices supply smaller treatment rooms through traveling carers. Elsiran refuges share news through the Fellowship of Open Doors. Teren is prominent along guarded crossings, while Ordan and Veyra are honored wherever waterworks and agreements need keeping.

Aurenhall

Capital of Aramere



The city

Aurenhall rises beside the Auren in a succession of stone terraces. Roofed stairs connect the busy lower quays with the council halls above. Grain dust whitens the dock railings; in the upper streets, messengers weave between petitioners carrying rolled plans and packets of provincial seals. River bells announce changing water levels as well as the hour.

Population: approximately 76,000. Humans form the largest community, with longstanding halfling neighborhoods, dwarven engineering families, and residents of many other ancestries. Household, occupation, and district shape daily life more strongly than ancestry alone.

Government and leadership

King Edric Vaun and the River Council govern the realm here. The city's own services fall to Lord Provost Ansel Dorr and a council of ward representatives. Ansel, a graying human former granary clerk, regards refuse collection and safe stairs as matters of royal dignity. He resents courtiers who promise public celebrations without paying for the cleanup.

The provost controls ordinary permits, street maintenance, and the watch budget. Crown guards answer to a separate command. A petitioner seeking justice against a royal contractor may therefore need both civic records and a crown hearing.

Defense and commerce

The civic watch patrols in shifts, supported by separate crown guards and a river patrol. Walls protect the upper approaches; river gates and raised storehouses secure valuable cargo. During floods, rescue and evacuation take priority over routine patrols.

Grain brokerage, milling, ropework, cart building, legal services, and government spending support the city. Ordinary equipment is plentiful. Specialist magic requires an appointment, a willing practitioner, and payment; the presence of temples does not make powerful services routinely available.

Specialist merchants occasionally handle griffon feathers, alchemical venom, or genuine warding materials, alongside a brisk trade in imitations. River patrols maintain notices about unusual aquatic animals as

Aurenhall

Capital of Aramere / continued

carefully as they record flood debris and navigation hazards.

Districts and landmarks

The Crown Terrace contains the royal residence, administrative courts, and formal gardens. Beneath it, the Council Steps are lined with copying shops, inexpensive food stalls, and lodgings rented by provincial petitioners. Lower Auren is a working district of warehouses, boatyards, and tightly packed homes.

The Compact House. This broad hall houses the River Council and public copies of its resolutions. Clerk-Marshal Jessa Orr, a precise half-elf with an excellent memory for neglected petitions, manages access. Visitors can inspect posted decisions; private provincial correspondence requires permission.

The Seven Granaries. Seven immense stores stand on raised foundations with separate access yards. Warden-General Tomas Reed's office is here. The oldest outer wall carries flood marks from several centuries. A public reserve tally is updated at each market week, attracting anyone with reasons to distrust grain prices.

The Measure Stair. A long riverside stair bears metal height marks maintained by the Bankwardens. Its lowest flights disappear in high water. Della Marr's crews use it for training, and families gather on the upper landing when the bells warn of a rising river.

Organizations and places to stay

The League of Bread and Mill. Led by Master Miller Oren Vask, this trade association negotiates delivery schedules and investigates adulterated flour. Bakers accuse its mill owners of protecting one another; Oren argues that public panic can ruin honest households before an inquiry begins. Its hall in Lower Auren accepts written complaints and commissions independent sampling.

The House of the Sheltered Drop. Senior healer Adra Fen directs Mereth's principal public hospice. Donations fund ordinary care and convalescent beds. She needs carriers, clean supplies, and assistance reaching patients; she will not sell priority in an emergency to a noble household.

The Reed Crown. Innkeeper Pella Norr rents quiet rooms near the Council Steps and serves a communal supper where provincial rivals must share the same bread. Her noticeboard lists clerical work, escort requests, and rooms available to petitioners with modest means.

Primary faiths

Ilyra - The Terrace of Returning Seed. A substantial garden-temple above the lower quays, led by Keeper Samra Vennel. Its Seasonal Keepers coordinate planting reports with Fairmead and teach visiting growers.

Mereth - The House of the Sheltered Drop. Adra Fen's public hospice is the kingdom's principal point of contact for the wider healing fellowship. Its traveling supply wagons serve Dunmere, Fairmead, and Threeways.

Elsira - The House of Many Lamps. Steward Iona Rell manages a large refuge near the Council Steps, offering beds to stranded petitioners and introductions to other Fellowship houses.

Ordan and Veyra - The Measure Chapel and Witness Gallery. These are separate sanctuaries adjoining the Compact House: one serves builders and inspectors, the other readers and record keepers. Their cooperation does not make either faith a department of the crown.

Avariel and Sovan. The Lower Bench offers mediation in Lower Auren; the Last Passage House tends funerals and family registers outside the busiest wards. Both welcome ordinary households as well as officials.

Connections beyond the settlement

The Granary Trust directs inspectors from the Seven Granaries to Fairmead and Dunmere, while western inspections pass through Threeways. The Bankwardens share gauge reports with Dunmere and Northbridge. An Auren Factors countinghouse handles river contracts here; its local member houses answer commercially to Speaker Mara Venn, not to the River Council.

Dunmere

The Downstream Markets



The city

Dunmere lies downstream of Aurenhall, near the point where Aramere's merchants begin preparing for Serathian inspections. Long sheds cover its sorting yards, and the streets between them smell of wet rope, river mud, and spices unpacked for inland buyers. A ship's bell above the customs house sounds whenever a new inspection roster is posted.

Population: approximately 43,000. Bargemen, warehouse workers, merchants, and families displaced by earlier floods give the city a mixed population. Several thousand seasonal hands arrive during the busiest grain shipments.

Government and leadership

Countess Selene Harrow holds the crown's local commission; elected aldermen manage the markets and neighborhood services. Selene, a composed human in her forties, has an injured knee from an old quay collapse and conducts many meetings while walking slowly along the docks. She insists on seeing the work for which she is asked to pay.

Harbormaster Iven Sarr controls berth assignments and channel notices. He is a broad-shouldered half-orc who knows which captains can move a damaged vessel without blocking half the harbor. He answers to the city, not to the merchant league.

Defense and commerce

City watch, river guards, and customs officers serve separate commands. Patrol launches pursue thieves and assist boats in trouble. Warehouse guards protect their employers' property, but do not possess general powers of arrest.

Grain, salted food, timber, rope, imported cloth, and river transport dominate business. Public scales settle quantities, while licensed inspectors examine seals and cargo manifests. The Auren Navigation Accord provides procedures for disputes with Serath, but a delayed hearing can still cost a merchant an entire season.

Quaymasters also track reports of large river serpents and other creatures found in backwaters after heavy floods. Boatmen compare routes and warn new crews away from reed banks where cargo has been lost for reasons unrelated to thieves.

Dunmere

The Downstream Markets / continued

Districts and landmarks

The Upper Ledger is the relatively dry commercial quarter of countinghouses and clerks' rooms. Below it, the Bargeward contains crowded boardinghouses and workshops. The Long Quay is a sequence of linked loading yards rather than one continuous street; gates and schedules can make a short distance surprisingly difficult to cross.

The Accord House. Envoys and inspectors meet here over navigation disputes. Registrar Neris Val keeps copies of recognized dues and prior rulings. She can explain what a document says but will not guarantee that a foreign officer will agree with her interpretation.

The Tally Exchange. Buyers bid on inspected consignments beneath numbered timber galleries. Exchange keeper Doran Pike, a halfling with a ringing auction voice, suspends traders who tamper with samples. The dispute board outside is one of the best places to find lawful paid work.

The Flood Lanterns. A line of elevated lamps marks the safe evacuation route from the Bargeward. Families contribute oil each autumn. Several lamp towers also store ladders, blankets, and rescue lines.

Organizations and notable establishments

The Auren Factors. Speaker Mara Venn represents the wider league; Dunmere's resident factor is Joren Pellis, who keeps an office in the Tally Exchange. He seeks reliable movement of cargo and predictable inspections. Members compete with one another even while supporting common negotiations. A league letter introduces a traveler; it does not exempt anyone from local law.

The Riverhands' Table. Chairwoman Bessa Quill coordinates dock crews, injured workers' support, and disputes over wages. Her association can halt work in a particular yard, but cannot command every worker. She hires witnesses to document unsafe conditions before an employer repairs the evidence.

The Empty Net. Run by former barge pilot Hadrin Moss, this riverside inn offers plain private rooms and shared loft beds. Muddy boots are expected, drawn weapons are not. Its morning meal is a dependable place to meet a captain looking for extra hands.

Primary faiths

Mereth - The Quayside House. Healer Senna Dorr leads this branch of the Houses of the Sheltered Drop, treating dock injuries and coordinating difficult cases with Adra Fen in Aurenhall.

Elsira - The Floodgate Refuge. Steward Torren Bell maintains sleeping rooms and emergency stores beside the Flood Lantern route. It shares warning lists with the Houses of Many Lamps and Open Doors upstream and westward.

Thessar and Leth - The River Stair and Departures Niche. Bargemen loosen a ceremonial knot at the open-air River Stair before departure. A small Leth shrine near the Tally Exchange receives travelers' coins and current route notices.

Veyra and Sovan. A Witness Tablet chapel beside the Accord House offers public readings. The Lantern of Names funerary chapel keeps records of those lost along the river; its attendants work with the Quayside House.

Connections beyond the settlement

The Auren Factors maintain member countinghouses in Aurenhall and purchasing agents at Fairmead. Grain inspectors report to Tomas Reed in Aurenhall; Bankwarden crews coordinate flood warnings along the same river. The Riverhands' Table has affiliated crews at Aurenhall, allowing injured workers to seek assistance after traveling upstream.

Fairmead

The Harvest City



The city

Fairmead stands northeast of Aurenhall amid productive farmland, connected to both northern routes and the river markets. Its skyline is a row of granary roofs and wind vanes rather than a palace. On market days, carts queue beyond the houses while drovers guide livestock through lanes built to keep them away from crowded food stalls.

Population: approximately 18,500, rising sharply during harvest fairs. Farming families maintain rooms here for market visits; halfling seed merchants, human growers, and dwarven millwrights have particularly visible trade communities.

Outlying orchard families sometimes strengthen their stock gates against owlbears and unusually bold boars. Seed keepers and caravan drivers exchange practical reports about creatures moving out of the uplands during lean years.

Government and leadership

Lady Warden Corren Tal holds the provincial commission. A former cavalry officer who now spends more time judging drainage disputes than reviewing troops, she favors practical agreements and dislikes exaggerated claims of ancient privilege. Fairmead's civic council chooses Market Reeve Orla Denwick, a human wool trader whose patience disappears when someone alters a posted fee.

Corren handles crown obligations and serious criminal matters. Orla oversees stalls, municipal measures, refuse collection, and minor market offenses. Both claim the right to close unsafe storage buildings, a rare overlap on which they usually agree.

Defense and commerce

Paid guards are reinforced during fairs by hired constables and a civic reserve. Low walls and stout gates protect the storeyards rather than every house. Livestock lanes can be closed quickly during an alarm.

Seed grain, wool, breeding animals, preserved food, and milling equipment dominate commerce. A visitor can buy excellent ordinary tools but must usually order specialized

Fairmead

The Harvest City / continued

arms from a larger center. Market inspectors examine samples before opening each fair, though they cannot prevent every substituted sack or concealed defect.

Landmarks and useful places

The Ninefold Market. Nine adjoining yards separate grain, livestock, wool, tools, and other goods. Bellkeeper Toma Sedge coordinates opening times and lost-property announcements. The lost-child bench beside his tower is also where separated travelers arrange to meet.

The Seedhouse. Keeper Ysol Bracken maintains a collection of viable seed varieties, planting records, and accounts of local crop failures. She follows Ilyra and works with ordinary farmers as readily as scholars. Samples are exchanged under written agreements so one wealthy buyer cannot remove a district's entire reserve.

The Old Dry Court. This raised enclosure served as a flood refuge before the surrounding market expanded. Its original paving survives beneath a newer roof. Travelers sometimes mistake its unusual stones for waystone material; local masons distinguish the two and discourage visitors from testing either with a hammer.

Organizations

The Seasonal Keepers of Fairmead. Led by Ysol Bracken from the Seedhouse, this regional gathering of the wider Seasonal Keepers maintains experimental plots and organizes help for damaged farms. Its members disagree about unfamiliar crops, but share observations openly at the spring gathering. Their blessings supplement labor and good husbandry rather than replacing them.

The Fair Scales Company. Master Assayer Bren Colwick directs an independent inspection partnership hired by both growers and buyers. Its office near the Ninefold Market displays calibrated measures. Bren, a meticulous gnome, refuses payment contingent on a favorable finding. His assistants often need protection when a large consignment fails inspection.

The Drovers' Ring. Speaker Nella Voss organizes grazing stops and the recovery of strayed animals. She is unrelated to the senior Ledger broker Cassian Voss and is tired of being asked. The Ring arranges paid work for scouts, animal handlers, and patient people willing to walk behind cattle in the rain.

The Bent Sheaf

Proprietor Alden Marr, a retired cook with an expansive laugh, runs this inn around a wagon court. Private rooms are scarce during fairs, but the covered yard rents secure sleeping spaces. He keeps a board of agreed labor rates to discourage travelers from accepting obviously unfair harvest contracts.

Primary faiths

Ilyra - The Seedhouse Sanctuary. Ysol Bracken's gardens and assembly room form the city's principal temple. As a regional meeting place for the Seasonal Keepers, it exchanges seed, field reports, and teaching visits with Aurenhall and Hearthglen.

Mereth - The Fairground Infirmary. A modest House of the Sheltered Drop treats market injuries and provides an isolation room when livestock fairs bring illness. Supplies come through Aurenhall; visiting carers also help nearby villages.

Elsira and Leth - The Drovers' Hearth and Fork Shrine. These two small shrines occupy opposite sides of the same sheltered market court. Elsira's steward arranges emergency beds with local inns; a lay Companion of the Fork posts road news. Fairmead has fewer large temples than the river capitals, despite its busy fairs.

Connections beyond the settlement

The Fair Scales Company holds an inspection contract with the Granary Trust and sends assessors to Dunmere when consignments are disputed. The Drovers' Ring negotiates northern grazing stages with Northbridge's Pasture Moot. Ysol's Seasonal Keepers supply teaching visits and seed exchanges to Hearthglen through the western market roads.

Northbridge

Gate of the Northern Plain



The city

Northbridge occupies a major river crossing on Aramere's northern approaches. Its defensive towers stand above long lines of wagons, cattle, and mounted travelers. Wind moves freely across the surrounding country, carrying news of distant rain before clouds reach the walls. Visitors hear Aramere's market speech alongside the accents of Vardane's pasture districts.

Population: approximately 14,200. Residents include bridge workers, herders, soldiers' families, merchants, and people with relatives on both sides of the northern frontier. National allegiance does not erase those relationships.

Government and leadership

Marchwarden Halen Vaust holds the crown's local military commission. He is a lean human veteran who dislikes raids, retaliatory raids, and speeches that make either sound inexpensive. The city charter gives civilian affairs to a borough council led by Speaker Meira Holt, a half-elf leather merchant with strong ties to northern drovers.

Halen wants dependable patrols and clear reporting. Meira wants troops paid on time so military requisitions do not become informal confiscation. Their disagreements usually concern expense and jurisdiction rather than loyalty to the kingdom.

Defense and commerce

A civic watch serves the town while a separate crown garrison patrols the crossing and surrounding roads. Teren's chaplains assist the garrison but do not command it. Closing the reinforced bridge gates is possible, though costly to local trade.

Livestock, hides, wool, grain, and horse trading sustain Northbridge. Repair shops specialize in tack, wagons, and weatherproof clothing. Travelers carrying animals should expect questions about brands, grazing agreements, and disease. Having money does not settle a disputed claim of ownership.

The northern watch logs tracks, livestock losses, and sightings of great predators alongside its ordinary road incidents. A traveler can inspect current warnings before crossing toward the open pasture or Vardane.

Northbridge

Gate of the Northern Plain / continued

Landmarks

The North Span. The crossing combines older stone foundations with repeatedly repaired upper works. Its current condition is a matter for the Bridge Office, not legend. Engineer Kessa Tor, a dwarf who carries a small notebook even to supper, closes lanes whenever inspection requires it despite loud objections from traders.

The Watch of Seven Lamps. A Terenite shrine overlooks the approach road. Chaplain Arven Dain tends seven lamps for those charged with keeping passage safe. The adjoining hall provides temporary shelter during closures and keeps names of missing travelers.

The Brand Court. A fenced inspection ground hosts livestock hearings and seasonal grazing negotiations. Its worn boundary posts display locally recognized marks. Adjudicator Fenna Rusk consults witnesses and records; she does not treat an unfamiliar mark as proof that an animal was stolen.

Organizations and lodging

The Crossing Ward. Commander Sera Tann leads the watch division responsible for the bridge, gates, and crowded approach markets. A practical human officer with a dry sense of humor, she values witnesses who stay to give statements. Her officers hire local guides when a problem moves beyond their familiar patrol routes.

The Pasture Moot. Convenor Garron Elt brings together herders and estate agents to negotiate temporary grazing rights. It has no army or independent court. Its leverage comes from agreements that hundreds of households need honored. Garron seeks mediators who can distinguish damaged fences from deliberate provocation.

The High Rail. Innkeeper Verra Skell offers enclosed stables, hot broth, and a quiet upper room used for negotiations. She allows delegations to leave weapons with the porter by mutual agreement; she cannot guarantee safety if either side arrives intending violence.

Primary faiths

Teren - The Watch of Seven Lamps. Chaplain Arven Dain leads the largest local shrine-hall. Its Wardens of the Seven Watches exchange escorts and rescue equipment with Threeways and Khardun's approach roads.

Elsira - The North Road House. Steward Mera Fen provides winter shelter and family messages through Mother Hessa Vale's Fellowship. The house receives travelers from Vardane as readily as Aramere.

Ordan - The Span Chapel. A small sanctuary maintained by the Keepers of the Measure stands near the Bridge Office. Kessa Tor attends its maintenance assemblies, which record obligations as well as blessings.

Ilyra and Sovan. The Pasture Bough is an open-air seasonal shrine outside the stock pens. The Quiet Gate is a small funerary chapel serving both garrison families and town households.

Connections beyond the settlement

The Pasture Moot works with Fairmead's Drovers' Ring on stock movements. The bridge engineers exchange reports with the Bankwardens and the Granary Trust concerning closures and emergency deliveries. Northbridge's Terenite wardens share shelter and escort information with the Roadward Chapel at Threeways.

Threeways

Where the Western Roads Meet



The city

Threeways stands in western Aramere where traffic can turn toward Khardun's approaches, the kingdom's interior, or the roads into Caldris. Wagon courts occupy more space than its modest administrative buildings. In the evening, travelers identify their lodgings by painted yard signs above the bustle of repair crews and late-arriving teams.

Population: approximately 9,600. Dwarven teamsters and merchants from the mountain roads mix with Aramere's farming families and Caldran carriers. The city is smaller than the great river markets but handles a disproportionate share of western traffic.

Government and leadership

Lady Magistrate Elowen Hart administers the crown's district commission from the Three Roads Hall. A human in her early fifties, she is courteous, exacting, and more impressed by a repaired culvert than a polished recommendation. Her jurisdiction includes Hearthglen and other dependent rural communities.

The city elects a Yard Council to oversee markets and public services. Its current chair, dwarf wheelwright Brannik Vale, wants the new western-road investment spent on surfaces, drainage, and safe stopping places. He openly opposes prestigious gatehouses that do little for travelers.

Defense and commerce

The city watch patrols the yards and markets; district riders serve the surrounding roads and villages. Registered caravan guards may carry arms but remain subject to the magistrate's law.

Haulage, storage, livestock fodder, repairs, and cargo transfer dominate trade. Khardun's metalwork moves toward the lowlands while food and timber travel toward the mountain markets. Caldran cloth, salt fish, and imported goods arrive through western connections. Buying a seat with a caravan is easier than hiring a private coach.

Caravan guards exchange reports about dangerous wildlife, troll-haunted bridges, and the safest overnight shelters. The most useful notice is dated, signed, and placed where the next company can read it.

Threeways

Where the Western Roads Meet / continued

Landmarks and institutions

The Three Roads Hall. Magistrate Hart's court shares a building with the district registry and a public notice gallery. Clerk Nerin Shaw receives petitions from village reeves. He is an elderly halfling who writes slowly but will explain what supporting details a petition lacks. A sealed letter from Hearthglen receives attention; it does not guarantee an immediate escort.

The Joined Yards. Three large caravan courts share a public well and repair lane. Yardmaster Maela Dorn assigns arrival spaces and mediates disputes over overnight obstruction. Different companies rent different courts, so there is no single master of every caravan.

The Turning Stone. An ancient waystone stands beside a road junction outside the busiest yards. Locals leave a small wheeled toy there when a child first travels away from home. Its original purpose is unknown, and the custom is evidence of local affection, not an explanation of its making.

Organizations

The Westroad Carriers' Compact. Convenor Rulden Pike coordinates shared rescue equipment, notices of road damage, and compensation discussions among participating companies. The Compact is a commercial agreement rather than a monopoly. Its members hire escorts and witnesses when missing cargo threatens their mutual trust.

The Threeways House of Open Doors. Steward Amra Cole directs an Elsiran refuge linked to Mother Hessa Vale's wider Fellowship. Beds are reserved for travelers in hardship. Amra helps people find family or safe onward travel and refuses to reveal a guest's private affairs merely because a creditor asks.

The Road Survey Office. Surveyor Lenna Dask leads a small crown-funded team evaluating the western routes. She needs local guides and records of seasonal washouts. Her appointment permits surveying public roads, not excavating private land or removing ancient objects.

The Brass Wheel

Innkeeper Fen Orwick, a cheerful gnome with a formidable ledger, offers clean rooms and guarded storage at this busy inn. His common room is a natural place to meet employers bound for either kingdom. Prices rise when storms trap several caravans at once.

Primary faiths

Elsira - The House of Open Doors. Amra Cole's refuge is the principal local center of worship, with a chapel beside the sleeping rooms. It supports Pell Underbough's Lantern House in Hearthglen through shared supplies and visiting stewards.

Teren - The Roadward Chapel. Warden Odran Vale blesses inspected equipment and helps organize escorts. His Wardens of the Seven Watches maintain contacts at Northbridge and the Khardun approaches; they are separate from the district riders.

Leth - The Three Coins Shrine. A small open shrine beside the Joined Yards serves departing travelers. Its Companions of the Fork exchange road reports with Fairmead's keepers and Caldran carriers.

Mereth - The Carers' Room. This small staffed infirmary belongs to the Houses of the Sheltered Drop. Senior carer Lysa Fen receives supplies from Aurenhall and teaches visiting village healers, including Nerissa Holt.

Connections beyond the settlement

The Westroad Carriers' Compact keeps correspondents in Aurenhall and Veycross, exchanging damage notices with Caldris's Southern Road Company while competing for customers. Lenna Dask's survey office reports to the Aramere crown in Aurenhall and exchanges boundary-route plans with Sered Aln's Caldran office. Granary Trust inspectors use Threeways as a western base for visits to communities including Hearthglen.

Hearthglen

The Village on the Western Roads



The village and its country

Hearthglen lies in western Aramere, northeast of Threeways and northwest of Aurenhall. Its cottages gather around a broad green above a small working stream. Beyond them are grain fields, kitchen gardens, coppiced woodland, and orchards on the gentler slopes. On a cold morning, hearth smoke lingers low enough for a person on the western lane to smell breakfast before seeing the village.

Most houses are timber framed on stone footings, with tile or thatch roofs according to household means. The central settlement has roughly sixty occupied homes and work buildings; many more residents live on surrounding farms. A low stone bridge carries the mill lane across the stream. No wall separates the village from the countryside.

Population: approximately 690 including its dependent farms, with around 250 living in the central settlement. Human and halfling families are most numerous; a few dwarven, elven, gnome, and mixed households are well established. Seasonal laborers are usually lodged by the farms that employ them.

History and daily life

Hearthglen grew around a sheltered stopping place and a dependable mill site. Its oldest surviving rent rolls are early Accord-era copies of earlier claims. Several families disagree about whose ancestors first made the green common land. None has produced a document accepted by everyone.

Hearthglen supplies the surrounding district rather than distant royal markets. It supplies grain, cider, cheese, wool, and finished wood to the markets around Threeways. Peddlers bring news, salt, needles, lamp oil, and tools too specialized to make locally. A well-equipped stranger is interesting, but travelers are familiar enough that their arrival does not stop all work.

Government and leadership

Reeve Mara Bellweather heads a five-member village council, chosen by household representatives at the winter meeting. Mara is a human woman in her late forties, a former teamster with wind-reddened cheeks and the habit of checking every knot herself. She manages the communal granary, records local dues, and carries petitions to Threeways.

Hearthglen

The Village on the Western Roads / continued

The council handles common land, minor disputes, and maintenance. Serious crimes and contested land titles go to Lady Magistrate Elowen Hart. Hearthglen pays district dues but has no resident noble household. Mara can hire help within a modest emergency allowance; she cannot grant titles, waive royal taxes, or promise money the village does not possess.

Defense

Constable Jory Kest and two paid assistants investigate theft, keep order at markets, and organize alarms. A rotating village reserve assists them, but most members are usually working fields or trades. A sustained emergency requires help from Threeways. Jory, a human former district rider with a stiff left shoulder, knows this and avoids presenting the militia as a professional army.

The green's bell uses distinct signals for fire, missing persons, and immediate danger. Families have assigned meeting places during an alarm. The mill loft and refuge cellar hold basic emergency supplies. The village sometimes employs travelers for searches, difficult escorts, or dangers its residents cannot safely handle.

Farmers have added stout latches to several outer pens, and the village bell has a warning pattern for a large beast near the orchards. Most alarms prove to be stray livestock or ordinary predators; Jory Kest insists on tracks and witnesses before declaring that an owlbear has come down from the woods.

Faith and custom

Ilyra receives the largest public observances, especially planting and harvest. Mereth has a small treatment room, while Elsira is honored at the inn and refuge. Sovan's remembrance rites are held at the hillside burial ground. People routinely attend more than one observance.

At the First Loaf supper, every household contributes something to the public table or the winter store. The ceremonial loaf is deliberately uneven: each portion represents a different household, and no one is supposed to complain about the size they receive. Complaints are nevertheless a reliable part of the evening.

The Copper Kettle

Proprietor: Tamsin Alder, a halfling woman with silver-threaded hair, brisk manners, and a gift for remembering who arrived hungry. Her two-story inn has six guest rooms, a common-room hearth, a stable for eight riding animals, and covered wagon space. Overflow guests can rent a pallet when traveling workers fill the rooms.

Tamsin serves bean stew, onion bread, orchard preserves, and excellent cider. She sets aside supper for a guest who cannot pay, honoring Elsira without making a spectacle of charity. The inn is Hearthglen's public meeting place, informal hiring hall, and the best place to hear several incompatible versions of the same event.

Bellweather Stores

Keeper: Halven Bellweather, the reeve's younger brother. This modest general shop sells food staples, rope, candles, blankets, hand tools, and traveling supplies. Halven keeps his accounts separate from Mara's civic ledger and becomes defensive when anyone suggests otherwise. He can order unusual goods through Threeways but cannot promise immediate delivery.

The Ember and Iron

Smith: Dorrin Ashmantle, a dwarf who moved to the village after years repairing caravan equipment. His forge produces nails, hinges, blades for farm work, horseshoes, and sturdy simple weapons. He repairs ordinary armor; a complicated commission needs materials and time. He reveres Teren through service and offers militia equipment repairs at cost.

The Four Seasons House

Keeper: Sister Elira Moss, a human Ilyran priest with soil usually caught beneath her nails. The timber temple opens onto a seed garden and covered gathering yard. Elira teaches planting customs, keeps local weather notes, and organizes shared labor after crop damage. She refuses to promise divine favor in exchange for the largest donation.

Hearthglen

The Village on the Western Roads / continued

The Willow Room

Healer: Nerissa Holt, a half-elf herbalist and lay follower of Mereth. Her two-bed treatment room adjoins the temple yard but has its own entrance. She treats ordinary injuries and illness, recognizes when a patient needs help she cannot provide, and arranges transport toward Threeways. Medicines and prepared supplies are limited; requests for powerful magic must be referred elsewhere.

The Lantern House

Steward: Pell Underbough, an elderly halfling widower and member of the Fellowship of Open Doors. A small communal refuge, it has eight ordinary beds and room for more during an emergency. Pell helps stranded laborers, displaced families, and travelers who cannot manage the inn's prices. Mother Hessa Vale's network supplies occasional aid, not an unlimited purse.

The Turning Mill

Miller: Dessa Rook, a broad-shouldered human woman whose practical jokes are much gentler than her bargaining. The watermill serves several farms and doubles as a place to exchange news. Flood markers on its doorframe are dated in different hands. Dessa posts grinding shares publicly, and disputes about those shares are heard by the council rather than decided by the miller alone.

The Hearthstone Green

An ancient waystone stands at the green's northern edge, with a bench placed nearby rather than fixed to it. Children call it the Hearthstone. Its surface shows little weathering and ordinary tools do not mark it. Villagers hang festival ribbons from a freestanding wooden frame beside it. No agreed local story explains who raised it or why.

The Orchard Rise

The eastern slopes contain small orchards and the village burial ground. Caretaker Oren Wold maintains the grave register and leads ordinary Sovanite observances. A weathered shelter provides a place for grieving families to sit out of the rain. An old path continues beyond the last managed orchard toward disused charcoal clearings.

The Old Limeworks

Beyond the worked fields stand abandoned lime kilns and a small quarry. Weathered sheds and unstable stonework make the place unsuitable for children's games, despite its enduring popularity. The council owns the approach track; adjoining grazing rights belong to several households. Any reopening would require agreement about hauling, water use, and safety.

The village council

Reeve Mara Bellweather chairs the council. Its other members are miller Dessa Rook, grower Halda Fen, carpenter Tobren Vale, and refuge steward Pell Underbough. Their responsibilities sometimes conflict: Halda wants field drainage repaired; Tobren wants the bridge timbers replaced; Pell argues that neither project removes the need for winter beds.

Meetings are held in the Copper Kettle's side room. Residents may attend, although strangers should expect questions about whom they represent. Council members are not automatically wealthy, and their public duties frequently interrupt paid work.

The Common Store Association

Coordinator: Halda Fen, a halfling farmer with a sharp eye for spoiled sacks. Participating households contribute food, labor, or coin to the communal reserve. The association maintains a granary beside the green and publishes a simple tally after each inspection. It works with Aramere's Granary Trust but remains a village institution.

The association can provide emergency food and organize repairs. It hires discreet help when losses cannot be explained, because an unfounded accusation of stealing from the reserve can divide the village for years. Halda dislikes waste and treats careful accounting as a form of neighborliness.

Hearthglen

The Village on the Western Roads / continued

The Lantern Circle

Coordinator: Tamsin Alder, working with Pell Underbough. This informal group checks on isolated households, arranges meals after illness, and keeps a list of safe places for travelers to stop. Members include farm workers, craftspeople, and retired carriers. Their influence comes from knowing who needs help and who has quietly been giving it.

The Circle has no legal authority and keeps no secret police. Its members can introduce a character to a family, organize a search, or contradict a rumor through firsthand knowledge. They are also quite capable of being mistaken.

People worth knowing

Jory Kest, constable. He speaks softly when worried and asks witnesses to begin again from the first thing they actually saw. His priority is bringing people home alive. He can offer a legitimate local commission for a search, but serious arrests require evidence and district involvement.

Sella Vey, letter reader and schoolkeeper. A young human trained in Threeways, she holds lessons in a room beside the Four Seasons House and helps adults read contracts. She is no priest of Veyra, though she admires the faith. She wants a weatherproof cupboard for records more than she wants rare books.

Bram Tiller, carrier. A cheerful half-orc with a two-mule wagon, he takes village goods toward Threeways and returns with orders. He knows current road conditions, ordinary carrier customs, and which excuses usually conceal an overloaded wagon. His route is regular, not an exact timetable.

Fenna Reed, woodland guide. An older elf who lives near the coppices, she advises on cutting rights and searches for missing livestock. She insists that people describe tracks before naming the creature they think made them. Her knowledge is practical and local, not universal lore about every ancient ruin.

Primary faiths

Ilyra - The Four Seasons House. Sister Elira Moss tends Hearthglen's one temple, its seed garden, and its covered gathering yard. She belongs to the Seasonal Keepers and exchanges reports with Ysol Bracken at Fairmead.

Elsira - The Lantern House shrine. Pell Underbough keeps the village's second principal worship site: a small Welcoming Door shrine within the refuge, supported by the Fellowship's Threeways house. The Copper Kettle observes the same hospitality customs without being another temple.

Other observances. Nerissa Holt's Willow Room is a treatment room, not a separate Mereth temple. Oren Wold conducts Sovan's burial rites at Orchard Rise without a staffed chapel. Households may keep small devotional tokens, and Dorrin honors Teren at his forge. The village has no resident clergy for every god.

Connections beyond the settlement

The Common Store Association remains locally governed but submits reserve tallies to Granary Trust inspectors visiting from Threeways. Bram Tiller exchanges road notices with the Westroad Carriers' Compact. Nerissa receives training and medicines through Lysa Fen's Threeways Carers' Room; Pell receives Fellowship visitors from Amra Cole; Elira shares seasonal reports with Fairmead. These ties provide people to contact without replacing the village council.

Caldris

The Chartered Crown



Land and character

Caldris lies west and southwest of the Crownspine and reaches around its southern end. Coastal farms, wooded uplands, market towns, and sea traffic give the kingdom several sources of wealth. Its mild coast contrasts with colder inland heights. Winter rain can make low roads difficult even when the sea remains navigable.

The kingdom consolidated in 204 AR around coastal lords and chartered markets. Its identity rests on negotiated rights: who may hold a fair, collect a toll, maintain a crossing, or bring a case before a particular court. These questions affect ordinary households as much as nobles.

Regional creatures & dangers

The coast and chartered roads are generally traveled safely, but inland woods, neglected bridges, and steep ravines offer shelter to trolls, great wolves, and dangerous hunting beasts. Wyverns have been reported over the rough western reaches; old holdings sometimes attract grave-robbers, restless dead, or guardians left behind by earlier masters. Offshore, unusual sea creatures and storm-tossed wreck sites present risks familiar to experienced pilots.

Travelers should distinguish rumor from a recent account. Charter towns post notices about closed bridges and troublesome creatures, and coastal watch captains collect reports of unfamiliar shapes in the water. A guide's local knowledge is usually more valuable than a dramatic tavern tale.

Queen Marwen Calder

Marwen governs from Caer Calden. A thoughtful human ruler with a restrained public manner, she favors common law, dependable roads, and predictable dues. She rarely announces a major policy before securing enough support to make it workable. Critics call this hesitation; allies call it remembering that a proclamation cannot repair a bridge.

Landed houses retain inherited jurisdictions, while chartered towns resist demands that ignore their privileges. The queen must negotiate taxation and public works with both. Her strongest supporters hope commerce will make cooperation more attractive than repeated local quarrels.

Caldris

The Chartered Crown / continued

The Crown Road Office

Royal Surveyor Sered Aln directs the office from Caer Calden. Its clerks document lawful tolls, inspect crown-supported bridges, and coordinate contracts across local boundaries. Sered, a patient dwarf engineer, wants consistent records that survive the retirement of the official who remembers why a fee exists.

The office employs surveyors, messengers, escorts, and independent witnesses. Its commissions specify where its authority applies; a crown badge is not permission to enter any estate or ignore a town charter. Disputes over the office's reach often matter as much as the damaged road itself.

The Charter Assembly

Speaker Alys Ferrow convenes representatives of participating towns when the crown requests common contributions or changes affecting their rights. It is an assembly of interests, not a parliament governing every part of the kingdom. Alys comes from Caer Calden's cloth trade and has a talent for presenting a united answer after very loud private disagreements.

The assembly supports road improvements while demanding clear accounts. Smaller towns worry that ports and the capital will capture the benefits. Its agents seek local testimony, especially when a proposed toll would shift traffic from one market to another.

The Southern Road Company

Director Merovan Saye leads a chartered commercial concern with offices in Caer Calden and Veycross. It arranges freight, secure storage, and caravan services along the routes toward Aramere. Its charter grants specified rights, not exclusive ownership of every road. Independent carriers regularly challenge its interpretation of favorable clauses.

Merovan is a polished human negotiator who values reputation because it makes future contracts cheaper. He hires practical escorts and investigators, but prefers a quiet settlement to a public victory that frightens customers.

Faith, borders, and daily life

Avariel's judges and Veyra's record keepers are influential, especially in Veycross. Elsiran inns and local shrines serve travelers throughout the kingdom. Coastal households honor Thessar before voyages, while inland growers keep Ilyra's seasonal customs.

The Woodland Articles of 558 AR recognized some protected forests along Elaran's southern edge without resolving every settlement claim. Near Bellford, a new cutting road may therefore be an economic opportunity to one community and a broken inherited promise to another. Caldris also competes with Aramere for western trade while relying on cooperation to keep it moving. Neither border is a simple line between friends and enemies.

Primary faiths

Avariel and Veyra have influential public institutions in the capital and Veycross. The Uncrowned Bench's advocates travel to chartered towns, while independent Veyran readers preserve local records. Ilyra's keepers serve the inland farms and woodland districts. Thessar's coastal shrines, Elsira's houses, and Leth's roadside altars are familiar to travelers. Nivara's Open Song links performers from Bellford to the capital and port.

Caer Calden

Capital of Caldris



The city

Caer Calden stands inland from Westhaven, where roads from the coast and southern interior converge. Pale stone walls enclose older wards, while newer workshops and wagon courts spread beyond them. The royal hill is visible from the cloth markets, but the sounds of looms, bells, and street sellers usually dominate daily life.

Population: approximately 58,000. Humans are the largest community, alongside established dwarven, halfling, elven, gnome, and other households. Prosperous craft districts and crowded laboring wards lie much closer together than a court visitor might expect.

Government and leadership

Queen Marwen Calder and her royal officers handle the kingdom's affairs. Civic government belongs to the burgess council and Lord Mayor Alys Ferrow, who also speaks for the Charter Assembly. Alys is a sharp-minded human in her fifties, proud of the capital's trading freedoms and conscious that she must sometimes bargain with the queen as both mayor and town representative.

Royal judgments, charter disputes, and ordinary city offenses pass through different courts. Clerk of Petitions Vennic Hall can direct a visitor to the correct office. He is famously unimpressed by anyone who demands immediate access to the queen without stating a matter for her to decide.

Defense and commerce

The civic watch and royal household guards have separate commands. Ward reserves train for fire and emergency duties. Walls and controlled gates protect the old city; outer workshops depend on patrols and neighborhood alarms.

Cloth, metal finishing, leatherwork, legal services, printing by hand-block and press, and inland distribution support the capital. Westhaven supplies overseas goods. Royal purchasing creates opportunities for artisans and intense arguments about which workshops receive contracts.

The Crown Road Office collates notices of dangerous creatures at remote bridges as well as fallen trees and impassable roads. Stoneworkers sometimes hire guards for surveys where old works or nesting wyverns make routine measurement unsafe.

Caer Calden

Capital of Caldris / continued

Districts and landmarks

Crown Hill contains the residence, royal offices, and ceremonial courts. The Loomward is a dense district of workshops and workers' homes. Chartergate houses guild halls, contract writers, and inns serving provincial visitors. Outside the walls, the Cartfields hold freight yards and livestock pens.

Calder Hall. The royal residence includes a public petition court separated from private household rooms. Its great chamber displays copies of town charters beside dynastic banners, a deliberate statement of Marwen's governing approach. Public access does not extend to the crown's confidential business.

The Hall of Balanced Judgment. High Advocate Edras Morn directs this Avariel temple and legal-aid foundation, a leading house of the Order of the Uncrowned Bench. A deliberate, silver-haired dwarf, he trains advocates to distinguish an enforceable agreement from a just one. The hall offers help according to capacity and need, not automatic victory in court.

The Charter Vault. Archivist Liora Penn keeps certified copies of recognized municipal grants. Visitors may consult public records under supervision. Missing or contradictory copies require investigation; the archive does not magically resolve their meaning.

Organizations and establishments

The Guild of Seven Crafts. Guild Speaker Borren Kel represents an alliance of major workshops. He wants apprentices properly trained and objects when nobles bring unregistered contractors into city work. Smaller artisans accuse the alliance of making entry too expensive. Its hall posts commissions for material recovery, delivery protection, and specialist assistance.

The Crown Road Office. Royal Surveyor Sered Aln's headquarters in Chartergate connects provincial reports to funded repairs. A damaged bridge can be a minor engineering problem and a major political one when several authorities disagree about who owes the cost.

The Blue Mantle. Innkeeper Sera Cale maintains a comfortable establishment used by provincial clerks and traveling craftspeople. A retired costume maker, she can help guests find respectable clothing for a hearing without pretending that fine clothes confer noble status.

Primary faiths

Avariel - The Hall of Balanced Judgment. Edras Morn's temple is a major house of the Order of the Uncrowned Bench. It trains advocates and sends them to Veycross, Bellford, and Westhaven.

Veyra - The Charter Chapel. Beside the Charter Vault, independent readers bless testimony and preserve copies of family and municipal agreements. They cooperate with the Witness Court's custodians while governing their own house.

Ordan - The Foundation Hall. Keepers of the Measure inspect public works and teach building standards. Sered Aln consults them, but the Crown Road Office and the religious order remain distinct institutions.

Mereth and Elsira - The Calden Hospice and Hearth of Strangers. These large neighboring houses share kitchens and referrals while retaining separate clergy and accounts. They maintain contacts throughout Caldris and with Aramere's western houses.

Nivara, Ilyra, and Sovan. The Lantern Stage holds Open Song performances; the Garden of the Four Boughs serves growers and garden workers; the West Gate Passage House conducts funerals and keeps family registers. These smaller temples serve substantial neighborhoods.

Connections beyond the settlement

The Crown Road Office directs correspondents in Veycross and Westhaven and maintains a records desk within Bellford's Articles House. The Charter Assembly draws delegates from all three towns. The Southern Road Company connects capital offices with Veycross dispatchers and Westhaven cargo agents. The Guild of Seven Crafts recognizes affiliated workshops in Bellford and Westhaven without controlling every artisan.

Veycross

The City of Witnesses



The city

Veycross lies on Caldris's southern inland routes, a natural destination for merchants and envoys traveling between kingdoms. Its streets are crowded with readers' stalls, advocates' signs, lodging houses, and messengers carrying document cases. Discussions that would remain private elsewhere frequently become public performances here.

Population: approximately 32,000. Foreign delegations and temporary petitioners add several thousand visitors in busy seasons. Residents are accustomed to unusual accents and remain suspicious of anyone who assumes that unfamiliarity makes a person easy to deceive.

Government and leadership

Lord Provost Cadan Rell administers the city under its charter and the Caldran crown. A reserved human widower, he wants Veycross to remain a livable city as well as a diplomatic symbol. The independent custodians of the Witness Court control the sacred precinct's procedures, not the entire city.

First Witness Sabren Holt represents the custodians to rulers and foreign envoys. Patient and difficult to hurry, Sabren insists that the court's value depends on access and trust across borders. The crown cannot simply order the custodians to turn proceedings into a political spectacle.

The Witness Court

Within the court's original stone boundary, people cannot knowingly speak a falsehood. They may remain silent, use narrow wording, or honestly repeat a mistake. The place does not read thoughts, compel answers, prove an inference, or force someone to honor a promise after leaving.

Custodians identify the recognized boundary and set hearing procedures. Public readers repeat statements for assembled witnesses; trained questioners help expose omissions. An unprepared visitor can still enter a deeply unfair agreement using entirely truthful words. No ordinary spell or claimed extension of the paving is treated as equivalent to the ancient court.

The court occasionally hears sworn claims about creatures, damaged caravans, or disputed rights to remove a dangerous beast. Testimony must describe what was actually seen; an impressive monster story is no substitute for a reliable witness.

Veycross

The City of Witnesses / continued

Defense and commerce

The city watch and the custodians' precinct wardens cooperate at public entrances under agreed procedures. Foreign bodyguards remain subject to local law. A hearing at the Witness Court does not put a visitor beyond the city's jurisdiction.

Document copying, translation, lodging, arbitration, banking, and ordinary trade support Veycross. Reliable witnesses and competent interpreters are valuable. Fees vary; the city has no single tariff that makes every legal service affordable.

Districts and landmarks

Witness Ward surrounds the ancient square and its archives. The Petitioners' Steps are lined with food sellers and inexpensive writing desks. South Market holds freight yards and caravan lodgings; Envoys' Close contains quieter residences rented by visiting delegations.

The Hall of Copies. Chief Archivist Tavia Senn directs supervised access to proceedings and deposited documents. A Veyran record preserves what was submitted or said; it does not sanctify the truth of every claim. Tavia trains assistants to make that distinction in every certification.

The Accord Bell. Cast to commemorate the settlement that began the Accord Reckoning, this civic bell sounds at public commemorations. Its platform is a popular meeting point. The bell itself is a later memorial, not a surviving instrument of the original negotiations.

Organizations and lodging

The Common Advocates. Convenor Halwen Rusk runs a charitable association near the Petitioners' Steps. Supported by donations and some Avariel clergy, it helps people prepare questions, understand contracts, and find interpreters. Halwen, a brisk halfling advocate, has no patience for the claim that a poor client should be grateful for an unfair bargain.

The Veycross Ledger House. Resident broker Demea Sol handles credit on behalf of Cevrane's wider institutions under senior broker Cassian Voss. Its contracts are public business. Demea is unfailingly civil and never confuses a customer's relief with agreement to less favorable terms. Independent advice is available elsewhere in the city.

The Open Question. Innkeeper Ossa Vell offers modest rooms and forbids paid questioning at the supper table. Guests are entitled to eat without becoming someone's impromptu witness.

Primary faiths

Veyra - The Sanctuary of the Unaltered Record. Adjoining the Witness Court, this temple serves readers, archivists, and petitioners. Sabren Holt represents the Court's custodians; the ancient square's effects are not something its clergy can reproduce elsewhere.

Avariel - The Petitioners' Bench. Advocate-priest Ressa Dorn leads this Uncrowned Bench house near the Petitioners' Steps. It trains alongside Edras Morn's Calden house and supports Halwen Rusk's Common Advocates, a separate charitable association.

Elsira and Mereth - The Guest Lantern and Readers' Hospice. These modest houses assist stranded delegations, exhausted petitioners, and injured travelers. Their stewards share referrals with Threeways and Caer Calden.

Leth and Nivara. The South Market Fork Shrine serves caravanners. Nivara's Courtyard of Voices hosts free performances and translation gatherings led by the local Open Song fellowship. Commercial Ledger offices are not public worship sites listed in this travelers' directory.

Connections beyond the settlement

The Common Advocates receive visiting Uncrowned Bench teachers from Caer Calden. Southern Road Company dispatchers exchange schedules with Threeways' Westroad Carriers' Compact. The Crown Road Office maintains a correspondent in South Market. Ledger House transactions connect this city to the Auren corridor; a borrower need not share the lenders' religion.

Westhaven

The Western Port



The city

Westhaven faces the Western Sea on Caldris's mild coast. Warehouses follow the sheltered waterfront, while narrow streets climb toward houses with bright shutters and salt-streaked roofs. Bells and signal flags pass news of arrivals faster than a messenger can cross the harbor district.

Population: approximately 36,000. Sailors from other realms, local fishing families, shipyard workers, and inland traders make the port notably cosmopolitan. Many households include someone who spends part of the year away at sea.

Government and leadership

Duchess Irena Westmere holds the coastal lordship and crown commission. She is a human woman in her sixties with a weathered complexion and a reputation for asking captains direct questions at formal dinners. She supports the queen's road program because a port's prosperity depends on moving goods inland.

The Harbor Council manages municipal port services under its charter. Portreeve Nallis Fen, a halfling former sailmaker, represents working trades as well as wealthy owners. Harbor dues and dredging expenses are their most persistent arguments.

Defense and commerce

The civic watch patrols the streets; harbor guards protect customs facilities and approaches. A small coastal squadron, shore defenses, and signal stations watch nearby waters. Captains still make their own preparations for a voyage.

Sea trade, fishing, shipbuilding, sailcloth, salted food, and coastal transport underpin the city. Merchants send goods inland toward Caer Calden and Veycross. Visitors can find ordinary nautical equipment readily; chartering a vessel requires a willing owner, a crew, and suitable conditions.

Harbor pilots exchange accounts of reef drakes, unusual deepwater creatures, and lights seen beyond safe channels. Dockside vendors sell protective charms; seasoned sailors tend to trust sound hulls, clear weather reports, and a capable lookout first.

Westhaven

The Western Port / continued

Districts and landmarks

Saltward contains fish markets, net lofts, and working families' homes. The High Quays hold larger warehouses and customs offices. Ropewalk is a long workshop district where straight open ground is valuable. Above the harbor, Beacon Hill houses prosperous merchants and the signal watch.

The White Beacon. Keeper Jass Orrel maintains the harbor light and trains signal crews. Its dependable operation is human work, supported by fuel, lenses, and constant maintenance. Storm damage or interrupted supplies can put vessels at risk without any supernatural cause.

The Mariners' Steps. Broad waterfront stairs lead to a shrine of Thessar and a memorial wall for the lost. Storm-speaker Hessa Dorn conducts prayers, keeps reports of recent weather, and tells captains when faith should be accompanied by staying in port.

The Dry Crown Yard. Master shipwright Varrik Senn directs one of the largest repair yards. A dwarf with an easy smile and exacting standards, he refuses to certify a hull he believes unsafe, even when its owner has influential friends.

Organizations and notable inns

The Harbor Pilots' Fellowship. Pilot-Master Mira Quen coordinates pilots familiar with local hazards. Membership requires demonstrated skill, not merely a fee. Mira hires help to mark shifting shoals and locate lost channel buoys. The Fellowship advises arrivals but does not own the sea or command the duchess's patrols.

The Saltward Mutual. Organizer Danel Ro, a human net maker, manages a fund for injured workers and families awaiting overdue vessels. Its members know which boats carry food, passengers, or suspiciously vague cargo. Their shared knowledge is useful, but no single member sees everything.

The Gull and Lantern. Innkeeper Vessa Tor rents rooms above a busy waterfront dining hall. Captains post legitimate crew vacancies here, and Vessa removes notices from employers who repeatedly fail to pay. The inn has secure baggage storage but no private immunity from the watch.

Primary faiths

Thessar - The Mariners' Steps. Storm-speaker Hessa Dorn leads the port's most visible worship, supported by the loose fellowship of Stormcallers. Captains bring weather reports as well as offerings.

Elsira - The Harbor Lantern House. Steward Rona Skell welcomes stranded sailors and families waiting for passage. The Fellowship sends messages between this refuge, Caer Calden, and Veycross.

Mereth - The Sailors' Hospice. Healer Daven Orr treats shipyard injuries and cares for crews recovering ashore. The House exchanges practitioners and supplies with the Calden Hospice.

Sovan - The House of the Returning Name. Keepers of the Last Passage record deaths at sea and conduct funerals when no body returns. Its attendants maintain the Mariners' memorial wall.

Leth and Avariel. The Outward Coin shrine faces the departure quays. The Harbor Bench is a modest Uncrowned Bench chapel where visiting advocates hear disputes over wages and treatment of passengers. Nivaran performers also gather at inns, without a separate major temple.

Connections beyond the settlement

Port clerks maintain a Crown Road Office desk for inland cargo notices. Southern Road Company agents arrange onward carriage toward Caer Calden and Veycross. The Saltward Mutual exchanges relief payments with Aurenhall and Dunmere's affiliated Riverhands crews when workers change routes. The Uncrowned Bench sends visiting advocates from the capital to the Harbor Bench.

Bellford

The Woodland Market



The city

Bellford lies in Caldris's northern interior, within reach of wooded uplands and the disputed country toward Elaran. The city's bell tower rises over a practical landscape of timber yards, cloth halls, and houses roofed with locally made shingles. Roads arrive carrying wool, boards, charcoal, orchard produce, and arguments about where each was lawfully obtained.

Population: approximately 13,800. Human farming and craft households live beside elven families with ties across the woodland boundary, dwarven saw and tool makers, and other settled communities. A visitor should not assume that every elf favors Elaran or every landholder supports new clearing.

Woodcutters keep paths clear around certain old groves, where guardian animals and less familiar woodland creatures have been reported. A notice concerning tracks or disturbed nesting grounds can delay a timber caravan as surely as a legal dispute.

Government and leadership

Baroness Talia Greymere holds the local lordship, subject to the town's charter and crown law. A human in her thirties, she inherited several unresolved boundary disputes and refuses to let her advisers describe them as merely a matter of drawing straighter lines.

Town Speaker Jerren Wale, a half-elf cloth merchant, directs civic business through the elected market council. He seeks reliable access to raw materials while preserving trade with forest communities. Both leaders prefer negotiation, but face constituents who regard compromise as surrendering inherited rights.

Defense and commerce

The town watch and the baroness's household force protect market approaches under separate commands. District levies can be called during an emergency. A patrol's presence does not settle the legal status of disputed woodland.

Wool cloth, seasoned timber, charcoal, fruit, and metal tools support Bellford. Timber merchants are expected to show where regulated loads were cut. Honest

Bellford

The Woodland Market / continued

documentation costs time and money, creating an opening for forged marks and pressure on small producers.

Landmarks

The Bell Ford. The old crossing that named the city now lies beside a newer bridge. A raised bell warns when water makes the ford unsafe. Bridgekeeper Anra Pell, an elderly human with a penetrating voice, has stopped more accidents by shouting than most guards have by drawing swords.

The Timber Measure. This long public yard grades boards and checks loads against their documents. Yardmaster Korr Denvik, a dwarf carpenter, can identify several local woods by smell. He will not claim to identify the exact grove where every plank grew.

The Articles House. Public copies of recognized agreements, including relevant Woodland Articles, are kept here. Reader Selai Nereth, an elf born in Caldris, explains the documents in both local and forest-court usage. She is careful about the difference between a translation and an interpretation favorable to one side.

Organizations

The Boundaries Commission. Crown commissioner Odel Marr heads a small traveling body that hears evidence about overlapping claims. Its Bellford office hires guides, survey assistants, and witnesses. Odel can report findings and recommend settlements; he cannot compel Elaran's courts to accept a Caldran decision.

The Joined Bough Guild. Led by woodworker Mira Dell, this association promotes verified timber purchases and repairable goods. Members include sawyers, carvers, and some forest suppliers. Its standards have commercial value, so a forged guild mark harms both the forest agreements and honest tradespeople.

The Hall of the Open Song. Nivaran performer Caelis Venn manages a modest performance hall and school. It hosts visiting artists from both sides of the boundary. Caelis welcomes shared work while recognizing that an invitation to perform does not confer ownership of a community's songs.

The Copper Bell

Innkeeper Borra Tern, a broad-shouldered human former charcoal carrier, provides warm rooms, substantial meals, and covered space for pack animals. She seats rival delegations at separate tables unless they ask otherwise. Her yard is a common hiring point for guides.

Primary faiths

Ilyra - The Joined Grove. Keeper Thessa Linn tends a modest garden-temple where field growers and woodland workers bring seasonal questions. Its Seasonal Keepers exchange practical knowledge with neighboring Elaran communities without speaking for Elaran's courts.

Nivara - The Hall of the Open Song. Caelis Venn's performance hall and school also serves as the city's principal Nivaran sanctuary. Its performers visit Caer Calden's Lantern Stage and Veycross's Courtyard of Voices.

Veyra and Elsira - The Articles Niche and Travelers' Hearth. The first is a small shrine in the Articles House, used by readers and witnesses. The second is a roadside shrine and emergency sleeping room supported by the Fellowship through Caer Calden. These are modest sites, not rival cathedral establishments.

Connections beyond the settlement

The Boundaries Commission sends findings to the crown through Caer Calden; its local readers share records with the Crown Road Office desk at the Articles House. The Joined Bough Guild works with affiliated Seven Crafts workshops in the capital and Westhaven shipyards. Open Song performers and Fellowship stewards regularly carry news along the same roads.

Powers Across Borders

Institutions and Influence

The Custodians of the Witness Court

Leader: First Witness Sabren Holt. Seat: Veycross. Reach: diplomatic and religious connections across Selarin. The custodians maintain access, hearing procedures, and records associated with the ancient court. Their credibility depends on refusing to become simply an instrument of the Caldran crown.

Their resources include precinct wardens, archives, readers, and experienced questioners. They do not possess an army able to enforce every agreement made before them. A commission may involve escorting witnesses, recovering a copy of a proceeding, or identifying what a poorly framed question failed to establish.

The Fellowship of Open Doors

Coordinator: Mother Hessa Vale. Bases: a network of Elsiran refuges rather than one controlling headquarters. Local contacts include Amra Cole in Threeways and Pell Underbough in Hearthglen. Houses share warnings, arrange shelter, and help separated families find one another while retaining considerable independence.

Hessa is known for remembering the practical details of a case after officials have reduced it to a political problem. The Fellowship can provide introductions, beds when available, and trustworthy local knowledge. It cannot guarantee immunity from every lawful inquiry. Its willingness to shelter people desired by creditors or rulers can still become a serious dispute.

Refuge keepers pass along signed accounts of dangerous crossings and creature sightings. Reports distinguish firsthand observation from rumor so a frightening story does not close a necessary road without cause.

The Auren Factors

Representative: Speaker Mara Venn. Bases: merchant countinghouses along the Auren, with strong connections in Dunmere. This league favors predictable duties, navigable channels, and peace between Aramere and Serath. Members remain separate businesses and may compete fiercely over the same cargo.

The Factors possess commercial information, warehouses, barges, and bargaining power. They hire escorts, auditors, translators, and negotiators. Their concern for stable trade can align with public welfare, but a profitable settlement may still leave a small supplier carrying most of the loss.

The Ledger Houses

Senior broker: Cassian Voss. Bases: independent houses linked through Cevrane's religious and financial institutions. Demea Sol represents the Veycross house. They finance shipments, property, and political projects through terms designed to preserve their influence.

Their agents work openly where local law allows. A Ledger claim is not automatically valid in every court, and an ordinary modern loan is not automatically a supernatural bond. Their influence rests on resources, carefully worded contracts, and enduring commercial relationships. Independent advocates and rival lenders remain important checks.

The Collegium of Surviving Works

Leader: Provost Istran Pell, based in Serathis. Local correspondent: survey scholar Maerin Doss, who rents rooms in Threeways while examining western reports. The Collegium documents ancient structures and sponsors expeditions, but its members disagree about patronage and excavation rights.

Maerin is a half-elf researcher who asks permission before taking measurements and is frustrated by colleagues who do not. A Collegium letter establishes an affiliation, not ownership of a site. Employment can include guiding a survey, making accurate drawings, protecting records, or finding people who remember earlier repairs. Modern scholarship has not recovered general control of the greatest ancient works.

The Road and River Accord Circle

Convenor: Advocate Sella Dain, based in Veycross with regular visits to Aurenhall. This new local association brings together mediators, clerks, and carriers interested in avoiding small commercial disputes becoming national grievances. It is not a treaty organization and cannot issue binding orders.

Sella is a human advocate with an untidy satchel and a talent for asking what each side actually needs. The Circle commissions cross-border inquiries and introduces witnesses to mediators. Its funds are modest, and its influence depends on the trust of the people involved.

Roads, Rivers, and Fellowships

A directory of shared connections

Institutions with a shared reach

Aramere's Granary Trust and Bankwardens work outward from Aurenhall through city officers, visiting inspectors, and local agreements. Neither institution owns every village store or watercourse. Threeways is their western point of contact; Fairmead organizes harvest traffic; Dunmere and Northbridge report river and crossing conditions.

Caldris's Crown Road Office operates from Caer Calden, with correspondents in Veycross and Westhaven and a desk in Bellford. The Charter Assembly brings those towns into common negotiations. Southern Road Company offices link the capital, Veycross, and the port, while independent carriers remain active.

Faiths that connect communities

The Houses of the Sheltered Drop share medical knowledge and supplies. In Aramere, Aurenhall supports Dunmere, Fairmead, and Threeways; Threeways supplies Nerissa Holt in Hearthglen. Caldris's Calden Hospice cooperates with houses in Veycross and Westhaven.

The Fellowship of Open Doors links refuges across both kingdoms under Mother Hessa Vale's coordination. Amra Cole at Threeways supports Pell Underbough at Hearthglen. Local houses remain independent households with their own resources and customs.

The Seasonal Keepers share records and seed rather than obeying a single high priest. Aurenhall and Fairmead are important Aramere meeting places; Elira Moss exchanges reports from Hearthglen. Bellford's keepers maintain their own connections with farming and woodland communities.

The Uncrowned Bench trains advocates in Caer Calden and Veycross and sends visitors to Bellford and Westhaven. Teren's Wardens of the Seven Watches link Northbridge, Threeways, and the mountain roads. Nivara's Open Song connects Bellford's school, Calden's Lantern Stage, and Veycross's Courtyard of Voices through visiting performers.

Traveling with an introduction

A temple letter can establish who tended you or what help you seek. A carrier's reference can describe your work. A town seal can confirm who authorized a petition. None promises that the next person has the beds, money, or authority to grant everything requested, but each gives that person a reason to begin the conversation.

A carrier's introduction may also name a trusted guide, an inn with secure animal pens, or a keeper who maintains the latest reports of threats along a remote road.